I agreed “reluctantly” to give in to their proposals and accept a twenty-five-percent reduction in rates over three years, phased in at five, ten, and ten percent, and hailed it as a great bipartisan solution. “H—l,” I wrote in the diary, “it’s more than I thought we could get. I’m delighted to get the seventy down to fifty. All we gave up is the first year 10 per cent beginning last Jan. to 5 per cent beginning this October. Instead of 30 per cent over 36 months, it will be 25 per cent over 27 months.”

I tried to keep the heat on Congress. I flew to Chicago in early July, ostensibly to speak at a fund-raiser for Governor Jim Thompson, but used my visit to the district of Dan Rostenkowski, chairman of the House Ways and Means Committee, to point out to his constituents that he held the fate of the tax-cut proposals in his palm. I urged them to write to him: “If all of you will join with your neighbors to send the same message to Washington, we’ll have that tax cut and we’ll have it this year.” I was told that the speech generated hundreds of letters to Rostenkowski, who subsequently became something of a conciliatory voice among the Democratic leaders in the House as we approached the finish line in the battle over tax reduction.

Matters started coming to a head shortly after that. In mid-July, Nancy flew to London to attend the wedding of HRH the Prince of Wales and Lady Diana Spencer. “I worry when she’s out of sight six minutes,” I wrote in my diary that night. “How am I going to hold out for six days? The lights just don’t seem as warm and bright without her.” But I had lots to keep me busy.

July 27, 1981, was a Monday, the beginning of a pivotal week that would determine whether our program got off the ground or crashed. Almost everyone following the events, from the members of our staff to the Washington press corps, said the battle was too close to call.